

Stale News

The story of a brooding and lovelorn journalist from Shillong



JET CITY WOMAN

by ANKUSH SAIKIA

Rupa

Price: Rs 195

Pages: 190

■ By Sonya Dutta Choudhury

Ankush Saikia's protagonist is bored. He doesn't enjoy being a newspaper sub-editor. "The paths in life we do not take—whether out of our own choice or of others—was playing on my mind," he says at the start of the novel, as he hangs around at the opening of an art exhibition in Delhi. It's the big city where he has lived for years, first as a drifting university student and then as a newspaperman. It's miles away from his native Shillong, and he's driven, like his fellow-north-easterners, to desultory days of drinking and chasing delicacies like chilly beef.

The only element of interest is TV anchor Naina. Once the two shared pink gins and passionate nights. Then Naina moved on, leaving our protagonist from the periphery obsessed. He's still brooding and besotted, when Naina re-enters. She invites the peeved journalist to keep her company while she interviews a French winemaker (brandishing her *kajal* pencil, she says, "A female reporter's greatest asset; I never go anywhere without it"). Later, she hangs out in a hotel room with a shady Afghan drug dealer, leaving the protagonist bemused and bedazzled. There's a mystery as well, and some social commentary on the dotcom boom and bust. But all of this, including the love story that never was, fails to grip. Like friend Bashan says, "Man, how many times you'll repeat that story? Stop talking about her, okay?"

Definitely not a book I would read either for the story or for the story telling, or even for the north-eastern backdrop which, doled out in stereotyped images of "chinks" on bikes in search of beer and beef, fails to capture the tragic splendour of the beautiful land and its people. ■



An Enchanted Journey

A lavishly illustrated volume of fifty absorbing stories that provide mythological answers to questions that fascinate children



THE PUFFIN BOOK OF MAGICAL INDIAN MYTHS

by ANITA NAIR, illustrated by ATANU ROY

Puffin Books

Price: Rs 499; Pages: 181

■ By Bunny Suraiya

Fortunate is the child who receives this beautiful book as a new year present. The stories are simply told, though never patronising in tone, and are short enough to be read at one go by the young reader, or to be read aloud to children without taxing the patience of the adult reader or the attention span of the little listener. The book contains 50 tales from Indian myths, and at under Rs 10 a myth, is very good going indeed, particularly when one considers the excellent presentation. Printed on art paper, bound between hard covers, the stories are charmingly written and lavishly illustrated, so it's a pity that the copy-editing of what is obviously a prestigious publication has not been as lovingly carried out. Right on the very first page appears the following sentence: "Surya's chariot was drawn by seven horses, each with gleaming coats." I don't mean to cavil, but books intended for children need to be more carefully proof-checked than those for adults because of the exemplary value

attached to them. Such quibbles aside, the content of this book is consistently absorbing and provides mythological answers to questions that fascinate children. Such as, how is the sun's heat tempered to prevent the earth from burning? What causes the moon to wax and wane? How did the island of Sri Lanka fall off the tip of India? What makes the sea salty? How come we have eyelids to make us blink, when there are no coverings for our nostrils and ears?

Indeed, I found some answers myself, including one I wasn't expecting in the least. Having always subscribed to the received wisdom that the primary Hindu trinity comprises Brahma the creator, Vishnu the preserver and Shiva the destroyer, I was intrigued to read in the second story that the real creator of the universe was Shiva, who apparently pipped both Brahma and Vishnu to the post. But, as Anita Nair takes pains to clarify on the acknowledgments page, she has authenticated these versions of Indian myths from three erudite publications on the subject, so who am I to disagree? If Shiva is to be credited with creating the universe, I'm willing to go along with it. And to happily present this book to all my young friends on each birthday in the new year. ■